GLASSHOUSE

BARBER'S CUT

Incisive observation is stock in trade for master strategist-turned-politician Prashant Kishor. Inspiration, though, is drawn from various sources. The latest one, it seems, is from a barber he met on the campaign trail. If Lalu Prasad's 15-year tenure was a 'Jangal Raj' of criminals, the wise gent told his fellow Bihari, then Nitish Kumar's era can be called a 'Jangal Raj' of bureaucrats. And both, Kishor concludes, have governed with the same brazen disregard for accountability. The razor-sharp wit hit home. Forgive PK for sporting a bit of stubble then. It isn't exactly a shave he may be going for these days to the barber's but to collect native political wisdom.

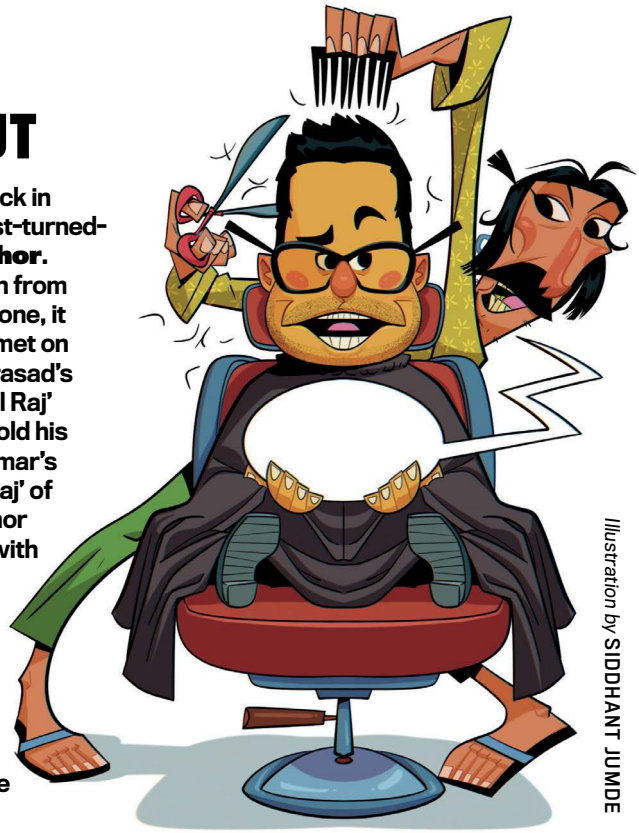


Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

Plate Diplomacy

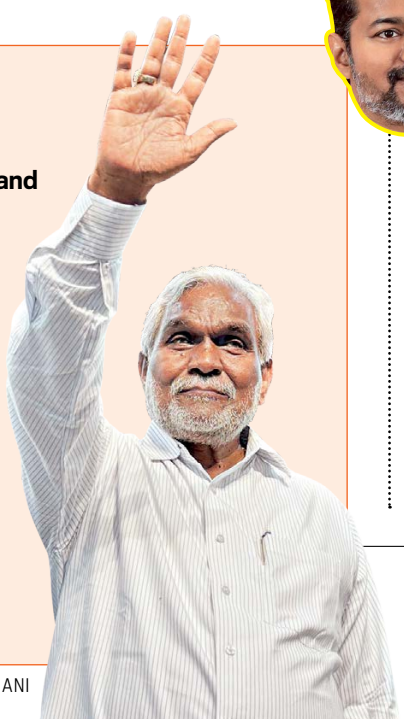
Bureaucrats in Madhya Pradesh are busy playing 'Spot the Difference' these days between current chief minister **Mohan Yadav** and his predecessor, **Shivraj Singh Chouhan**. The latest? The dinner parties the two have hosted. The first was a cosy dinner Chouhan threw shortly after becoming Union agriculture minister at Delhi's Pusa Road guest house, inviting only IAS officers, and none from the IPS and IFS. Last month, Yadav threw his own dinner party, inviting gentlemen of all here services—IAS, IPS, IFS. His purpose? To leverage their influence for the state, though the non-IAS guests barely got a word in. Chouhan's dinner got high marks for the warmth and personal touch, but there is no word on the food at either feast.





Family Business

On August 30, former Jharkhand chief minister Champai Soren's defection from the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha to the BJP made the news, but it was his son, Babulal Soren, who sparked whispers that he may be angling for a party ticket. This father-son act isn't restricted just to Jharkhand, politics is becoming family business even in its neighbouring state. In Bihar, former state BJP chief Ramjatan Sinha returned to the Congress, not solo, but with son Amit in tow. Then there's muscleman Sunil Pandey, who also switched to the BJP, bringing along his son Vishal Prashant. Meanwhile, the RJD isn't immune to *parivarvaad* either. Word is it might field Ajit Singh, son of party boss Jagadanand Singh, for the upcoming bypoll. In the game of thrones that is Indian politics, family connections help keep the seats warm.



ANI

UPFRONT

Revival Yatra

Marking time after Bharat Rashtra Samithi's debacle in the general and state polls, **K. Chandrashekar Rao** is endeavouring to start afresh. He'll embark on a bus tour of Telangana later this month, hoping to tap the resentment of the people against the state government on multiple counts. He plans to interact with farmers and rejuvenate the cadre in the run-up to the local body polls. There may be one problem, though. The defection of his MLAs to the Congress—10 of 38 have already crossed over.



Pachyderm Proportions

Like other actors before him who have straddled the worlds of cinema and politics, Tamil actor Vijay too found a vehicle for his ambitions—the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK)—on Feb. 2. Last fortnight, he launched a flag and an anthem too. Except that the two elephants on the flag had the BSP running to Chief Electoral Officer Satyabrata Sahoo five days later, citing their party's integral association with the animal as its poll symbol. And you thought making a mark at the hustings was the only elephantine struggle in a neta's life?



Kaushik Deka with Amitabh Srivastava, Rahul Noronha and Amarnath K. Menon